| | |
|---|---|
| Post-acquisition, salary improves to bigger margins (9L PA averaged over 9 years) | You've become a middle manager (12L PA averaged over 9 years) |
| *In another 9 years:* 76.8L + 8*9L = **1.57C** | *In another 9 years:* 42L + 12*9 = **1.50C** |

| **Later stage startup employee** [4] | **Corporate joinee** |
|---|---|
| *3 years' time:* 40,000*12*3 + 20L(equity) = 34.4L | *3 years' time:* 6L (averaged) * 3 years = 18L |
| After 3 years: Salary improves at widely-prevalent 5% per annum and your annual compensation is 8L | You've become an early middle manager (10L PA averaged over 5 years) |
| *In another 5 years:* 29.4L + 8L*5 = **69.4L** | *In another 5 years:* 10L*5 + 18L = **68L** |

When a newer start-up employee cashes in his options after the vesting schedule, usually 4-6 years after joining the company, he was guaranteed a bigger payoff. Despite paying taxes on the options, the payoff will leave him in a better position than any corporate employee. But, a later-stage startup employee didn't enjoy the magical returns of an early adopter. Given that both had similar skills in employability, the numbers converged at the same place and the difference in total remuneration wasn't much. In the probabilistic magical place that a startup scales up dramatically and gets acquired, the windfall is immediate but in the long run, a corporate employee's earnings converged with a startup employee. Unless, you are a first 50 employee in the company, the financial motivation wasn't convincing.

If financial reasons weren't stimulating, it then mattered to look at the life of employees at the two workplaces.

**How Lifestyle Differs**

| **Newer start-up employee** | **Corporate joinee** |
|---|---|
| Blood, sweat and ramen days | Is comfortable in a decent apartment and has good food everyday |
| 3 years look like eons after which you can take a vacation | Yearly foreign and tri-annual domestic vacations later, you realize how awesome life can be (shown in Week 2) |
| 7 years later, the home fills you with joy and the car smells success every time you sit in it. | You bought a car and the downpayment for home is a little far but the savings are adding up (not very far away though) |

With neither financial nor lifestyle reasons backing the decision to choose startups, it meant I needed qualitative reasons. As Antonio Garcia Martinez remarks in 'Chaos Monkeys', '*the only chance you have of your company making it through is if all your*